

Coverstory **SACHIN TENDULKAR**

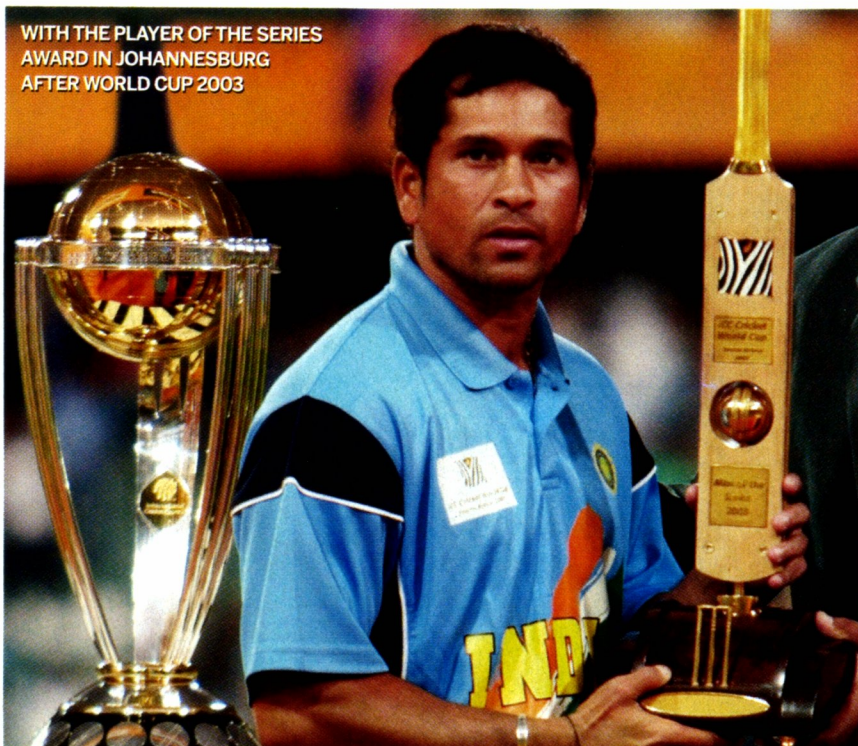
raging turners, on cold, cloudy days and blazingly hot ones; at home surrounded by family and fans and away amidst loneliness; when the body is obeying all commands and when pain and fatigue bring you to your knees. And he hasn't just survived, he's left his imprint on every situation. It is a colossal achievement. On his first tour of England he batted against Eddie Hemmings who had made his first class debut seven years before Tendulkar was born. He now shares a dressing room with kids who were having their umbilical cord cut when he was scoring his first century.

Along the way he has had to live with irrational expectations; with people who could find no faults in him to others going round with a magnifying glass searching for them. He has walked out to bat amidst deafening cheers and yet had to learn not to hear them. He has had people offering him everything under the sun; wealth, reverence, gratitude but all he has ever wanted is to play cricket for that to him was the destination, not the rewards that lay beyond. In that,

he is like Sir Garfield Sobers, the only other man to play international cricket for 20 years. Sobers too played the game for the thrill it afforded him. Is that the secret of longevity then? To enjoy the ride? Every morning?

Beneath the child-like enthusiasm though lies a man who knows his game better than almost anybody else. Tendulkar thinks very deeply about the game, his mind simplifying its nuances so astonishingly as to enable him to walk out to bat with his mind absolutely calm and ready; so that he faces neither the bowler, nor the conditions but merely the ball on its way to him. Tendulkar is very much an instinct player but it is an instinct that has been sharpened by intense preparation.

And on days when the mind is calm and free of all thought, he enters a zone that bowlers around the world would instantly recognise. "It's just a level of concentration when you forget everything else," he says in the interview in this issue. In fact he has often talked about a cluttered mind giving him, or indeed any batsman, less time to play shots. "Against the same bowler, under



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